



HUMANITAS
INSTITUTE

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Brilla Pax Middle School

School Website: <https://brillaschools.org/our-schools/brilla-pax-middle-school/>

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Artificial Intelligence Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

Overall Classification: SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Executive Summary

Brilla Pax Middle School shows a partial alignment with classical education principles. Public materials from the Brilla Pax site emphasize a “virtue-centered” and “classical approach” to education, with references to rigorous curricula, authentic texts, and a blended-learning/co-teaching model. These signals indicate a classical orientation in several domains (notably through formation of character and adoption of classical framing). However, explicit classical elements that define a fully classical program—such as a stated seven liberal arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; trivium; quadrivium), a rigorous Great Books/Great Conversation emphasis, explicit Socratic pedagogy, or a “living curriculum” as the core of faculty and parent partnerships—are not robustly documented in the public materials reviewed. The school notes a transition from 5th grade in 2025 to grades 5–8, and it frames its mission around virtue-centered education and college readiness, rather than an exclusively formation-first or Great Books-centric model.

Overall, the school lands as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL across category criteria, with stronger signals in categories tied to character formation and classical framing, but weaker signals in areas that require explicit Great Books/Trivium/Scholé pedagogy, liturgical or theological grounding, and expansive parent/community classical practices. This yields an aggregate rating of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL.

Executive insights per category (category-by-category scoring is explained in detail below). The Brilla Pax materials cited include: the public Brilla Pax Middle School description and related Brilla Pax Elementary/Middle School content, which describe a virtue-centered, academically rigorous, classically oriented program and a blended/co-teaching model. See the Brilla Pax materials for evidence of the site’s stated aims and pedagogy.

What would move the needle for Brilla Pax toward a fuller CLASSICAL classification is explicit, public articulation of: a Seven Liberal Arts curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; Trivium; Quadrivium), robust Great Books/Great Conversation commitments, explicit Socratic pedagogy in upper grades, a stated liturgical/community or theological framework, a clear “living curriculum” model for faculty, and a formal, public commitment to parent-as-co-educator partnerships. These steps would strengthen alignment with the Six Essential Elements framework and its keyword indicators.

- What would move the needle (SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL → CLASSICAL)
- Publicly articulate and implement a Seven Liberal Arts-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; with Quadrivium components) and a formal Great Books program.
- Publish evidence of Socratic/dialogic pedagogy in upper grades and memory/recitation components in lower grades.
- Establish a liturgical or theological grounding (or clearly articulate how theology informs other disciplines) and reference liturgical/community practices in school life.
- Feature explicit “living curriculum” statements about the faculty as mentors and living exemplars, with parent-partnership language (parents as co-teachers) and predictable community engagement.
- Increase parent-facing programming that educates parents about classical education (book studies, lecture series, “family formation” activities), and welcome open campus visits as a regular practice.

The analysis below follows the required keyword analysis framework using the Six Essential Elements keyword indicators.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Brilla Pax Middle School materials describe a “virtue-centered education” and emphasize character formation as core aims, including language about developing “the minds and hearts” of students toward college readiness. This signals a moral formation orientation aligned to some classical expectations around virtue and character. - The public materials discuss a “classical approach” and the use of authentic texts within a rigorous framework, further signaling a classical orientation in foundations. - Direct references to liturgical, theological, or explicit metaphysical grounding are not prominent in the Brilla Pax Middle School public materials; theology/liturgy are not foregrounded in the snippets reviewed here. This weakens the case for a formal liturgical/theological base in this category, though the presence of virtue-centered formation remains relevant.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: virtue, character, classical approach (signals in the foundational sense of virtue-centered formation and a classical framing). - Absent/Not clearly present: explicit mentions of truth/goodness/beauty as transcendental absolutes; liturgy; theology; liturgical practices.

Negative keyword indicators - No clear presence of secular humanism/values-clarification signals; no explicit relativism signals in the available public materials for this basis. However, the absence of explicit transcendental-metaphysical language limits a full classical match in this category.

Why this rating - The school clearly signals virtue-centered formation and a classical framing, which aligns with the Positive Keywords for this category. The lack of explicit transcendental/metaphysical language (truth/goodness/beauty as real, knowable absolutes) and liturgical/theological grounding reduces the category to SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: Brilla Pax content describing virtue-centered education and classical approach.

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - Brilla Pax emphasizes formation of virtue and character (formation of minds and hearts) as core aims, and notes virtue-centered education, indicating formation is valued alongside intellectual development. This aligns with the classical aim of formation of virtue and wisdom beyond mere information. - The school explicitly frames outcomes in terms of college readiness and success (e.g., “succeed in college and beyond”), which signals a practical orientation toward life after schooling, not purely leisure/paideia or contemplative formation. This introduces an element of workforce/college-readiness emphasis rather than a purely formation-first stance.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: formation, virtue, wisdom (through formation-language); liberal education/paideia language is not explicit, but the virtue-centric formation motif is present; the “great conversation”/pursuit of truth, goodness, beauty is not explicitly stated. The presence of formation/virtue signals alignment with the classical mission in some sense. - Absent/Unclear: explicit statements about pursuing truth, goodness, and beauty as real transcendent goals; explicit language about paideia/Scholé or contemplation as a primary goal; explicit communal or classical heritage commitments beyond virtue and formation.

Negative keyword indicators - “College and beyond” framing appears, which can be interpreted as workforce/college-readiness emphasis (negative in this category’s strict sense if taken as job-prep orientation). The Brilla Pax language mentions college readiness, which is a non-classical emphasis in some classical formulations.

Why this rating - The core emphasis on virtue-centered formation supports a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating. The explicit emphasis on college-readiness/workforce orientation and the lack of explicit statements about pursuing truth/goodness/beauty in a transcendent sense (as the category’s Positive keywords highlight) push this toward SOMEWHAT rather than CLASSICAL.

Citations: Brilla Pax site describing virtue-centered formation; reference to college readiness.

Element 3: School Curriculum — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site states a “classical approach” and the use of authentic texts, indicating a curriculum framed in classical terms and a focus on substantial content. It mentions a rigorous, evidence-based curriculum, which aligns with the classical emphasis on deep, substantial learning rather than surface, skills-based work. - Elementary materials reference alignment to Common Core Standards in early grades, with an emphasis on cross-curricular content and a strong content foundation. The explicit Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium elements are not named on the public pages, which tempers the alignment to a full classical curriculum (the classical lexicon emphasizes the Seven Liberal Arts and Great Books among others).

Positive keyword analysis - Present: classical approach; authentic texts; rigorous curricula; range of rich content; cross-curricular activities; emphasis on foundational content (e.g., “Common Core Standards” alignment in Elementary materials, which is not inherently classical but indicates a heavy curricular focus). - Absent/Unclear: explicit seven liberal arts terms (grammar, logic, rhetoric) or explicit Quadrivium/Great Books commitments; direct references to Great Books or Great Conversation; explicit historical engagement or “great books” canon.

Negative keyword indicators - The explicit absence of Great Books, Trivium/Quadrivium, and strong history-as-subject beyond general content-laden language is a negative signal for classicism in Curriculum.

Why this rating - The presence of a “classical approach” and emphasis on authentic texts points toward SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL. The lack of explicit Great Books/Trivium/Quadrivium articulation and explicit Great Conversation commitments in public materials keeps it from CLASSICAL.

Citations: Brilla Pax materials describing a classical approach and authentic texts; elementary Common Core alignment language.

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Brilla Pax materials indicate a blended-learning/co-teaching model and a rigorous approach, which signals a blend of classical framing with modern pedagogy. There is no explicit mention of Socratic seminars, scholé, chant, or memory work on the public pages provided, but the classical framing and “authentic texts” imply engagement with substantial content and discussion in some form. - There is no explicit articulation of the classical pedagogy signals (Socratic seminars, chanting/memory, recitation, or formal rhetoric training) on the Brilla Pax site excerpt provided.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: classical approach (1) - Supporting signals: blended learning and co-teaching (2) (these are modern pedagogical signals that can coexist with classical framing) - Absent/Unclear: explicit Socratic dialogue, scholé, memory work, recitation, chanting, or upper-school rhetoric training.

Negative keyword indicators - Absence of explicit “Scholé”/restful learning language, Socratic discussion, or classical pedagogy signals reduces the strength of a fully classical pedagogy signal.

Why this rating - The pedagogy appears to be a modern hybrid with a classical framing—but public materials do not robustly show the explicit classical pedagogy signals (Socratic dialogue, memory work, chanting, ritualized recitation). This yields a SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rating.

Citations: Brilla Pax site content describing blended learning and classical framing.

Element 5: School Faculty — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The public Brilla Pax materials describe teachers and staff in terms of school roles (e.g., “faculty” and “learning environment” in a way typical of many modern schools), but there is no explicit public articulation of faculty as the “living curriculum,” “portrait of teacher,” or “master-teacher mentorship” in the sense described by classical education sources. The explicit “living curriculum” concept, teacher as mentors modeling virtue, and a formal faculty culture are not described in the provided public materials.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: none of the explicit classical-faculty signals (e.g., “living curriculum,” “faculty of friends,” “portrait of a teacher,” etc.) appear in the Brilla Pax public materials provided here.

Negative keyword indicators - The lack of explicit classical-faculty language (per the Six Elements lexicon) pushes this category toward NOT CLASSICAL.

Why this rating - With no explicit “living curriculum” or faculty-as-virtue-model language documented publicly, this category is NOT CLASSICAL under the rubric.

Citations: Brilla Pax site excerpts describing faculty in general terms, without the explicit classical-faculty framing.

Element 6: School Parents & Community — NOT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Brilla Pax materials reference serving families and building virtuous culture, but explicit parent-partnership structures (parents as co-teachers, robust parent formation programs, open campus with routine parent visits) are not clearly described in the public excerpts provided. The canonical Six Elements framework emphasizes active parent partnership, formation, and open visits; those public signals are not robustly documented in the Brilla Pax materials examined here.

Positive keyword analysis - Present: mention of families and a focus on “families” (community-oriented language) and “visit/engage” language in the public page (e.g., “Families” are cited as part of mission, and an invitation to visit is present). However, these are less explicit about parent-as-co-teacher or formal parent-education programs.

Negative keyword indicators - Absence of explicit parent-as-co-teacher commitments, parent education offerings, and strong open-campus/parent-visit language beyond a general invitation to visit.

Why this rating - Given the absence of explicit, codified parent-partnership and continuous parent-education language in the public materials, this category is NOT CLASSICAL.

Citations: Brilla Pax site content referencing families and visit invitation.

What Would Move the Needle

- Explicitly publish and implement a Seven Liberal Arts-based curriculum (grammar, logic, rhetoric; with Quadrivium considerations) and a robust Great Books/Great Conversation program, with public-facing syllabi and sample year-by-year sequences.
- Publicly document and operationalize a Socratic pedagogy framework in upper grades (Socratic seminars, dialectic discussions) and memory/recitation practices (Scholé-inspired routines) as core teaching methods, with classroom examples and rubrics.
- Establish explicit liturgical/theological grounding (even if broadly Christian) and reference liturgical/-community practices (chapel, prayer, liturgical calendar) as part of daily life and curriculum—clearly linking theology to other disciplines as a Mistress Science.
- Build a formal “living curriculum” model for faculty, including mentorship, teacher-formation programs, faculty seminars, and living-virtue exemplars, with public documentation of teacher profiles that highlight virtue and mastery.
- Develop and publicize a robust Parent & Community program (parent formation, classical book clubs, parent visitation policies, and co-teaching partnerships) with explicit language about parents as co-educators and school-community partnerships.
- Enhance transparency around “College and Career Readiness” language to align with classical aims: reframe as “human flourishing through liberal education” rather than primarily job-readiness, or clearly articulate a classical telos that integrates both formation and career preparation harmoniously.
- Expand language on the Great Conversation, Great Books, and classical canon in public-facing pages to signal a fuller classical curriculum to families and accrediting bodies.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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